analyze, and disseminate information across the international community (Keohane 1984; Dai 2002). This information spans an array of critical domains, including compliance with international rules, environmental conditions, economic performance, public health metrics, security concerns, trade patterns, demographics, and more. By providing reliable data, IOs empower states to make informed decisions, promote transparency, and facilitate cooperative solutions. In many cases, the collection and provision of such information are embedded within IOs' formal mandates.[3]

To fulfill their information-related mandates, IOs rely on diverse sources. For example, the IMF needs economic data from member states to forecast global trends and identify systemic risks, while the IAEA depends on accurate reports about nuclear programs to verify compliance with international agreements. A lack of accurate or timely information can have dire consequences, including undermining compliance with international laws, weakening accountability for human-rights violations, and jeopardizing initiatives in peacekeeping or public health.

In some cases, IOs supplement state-provided data with independent means of information collection. The IAEA, for example, dispatches inspectors to nuclear facilities (Thorne 1992), the European Commission sends monitors to assess the fairness of elections (Kelley 2009), and the IMF conducts field missions to assess economic conditions on the ground (Clark and Zucker 2024). Satellite imagery, open-source intelligence, and other technologies also play a role in expanding IOs' informational reach. However, IOs are often constrained by limited authority to gather data independently, as member states typically hesitate to empower them with far-reaching surveillance capacities (Abbott and Snidal 1998). States worry that granting IOs extensive autonomy might diminish their own sovereignty, lead to bureaucratic overreach, or even enable IOs to pursue independent agendas at odds with state interests (Barnett and Finnemore 1999).

As a result, IOs frequently rely on member states to provide critical information, whether related to their own activities or to the behavior of other states (e.g., through naming and shaming tactics [Hafner-Burton 2008]). Yet, as emerging scholarship highlights, states' willingness to share accurate information is often governed by self-interest. Leaders may provide information that serves their agendas while withholding or distorting data that could be politically damaging (Terman and Voeten 2018). For example,